Setting up a Zoho Creator account and exploring the platform architecture and interface.

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Introduction

Zoho Creator is a powerful low-code application development platform that enables users to create business applications with minimal coding effort. In addition to application development, it provides an Administration Dashboard that helps administrators manage applications, users, security, deployments, and organizational settings from a centralized location. During this exploration, various modules available in the dashboard were studied to understand their functionality and purpose. Each module contributes to the efficient management, deployment, monitoring, and maintenance of applications. This report presents the features and observations made while exploring each module of the Zoho Creator Administration Dashboard.

Applications

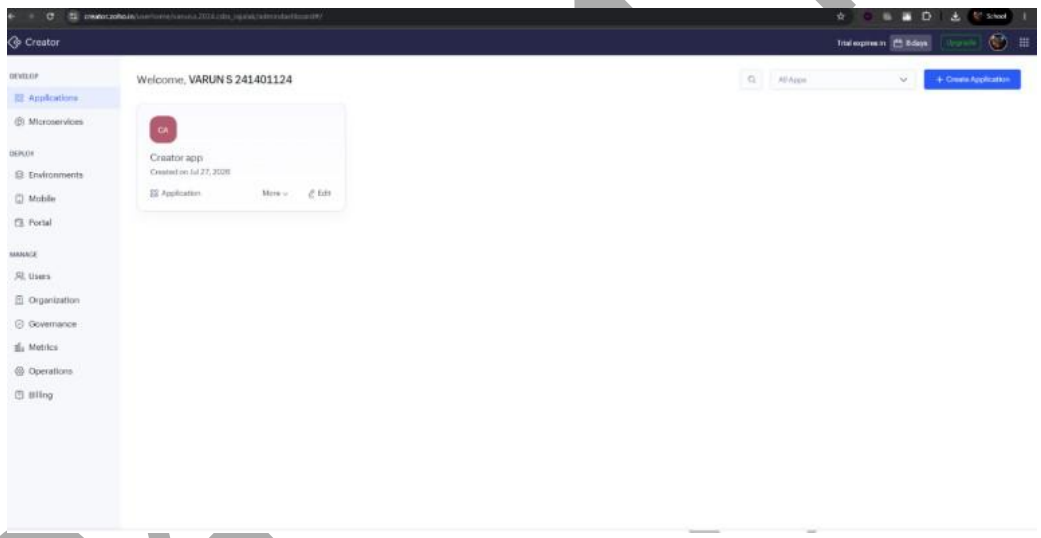


Fig 1: The Applications page, showing the app created during setup.

The Applications module serves as the primary workspace where all applications created in Zoho Creator are displayed. It allows administrators to create, edit, and organize applications efficiently from a single interface. Users can quickly search for applications and manage them using the options provided on each app card. In simple words, this is basically the home screen of Zoho Creator. The moment I logged in, I could see my app named "Creator app" sitting there, along with the date it was created. There is also a big blue "Create Application" button at the top right, which makes it very easy to start a brand-new app whenever needed. It feels a lot like an app launcher, everything I build in Zoho Creator will show up here as a neat little card.

Microservices

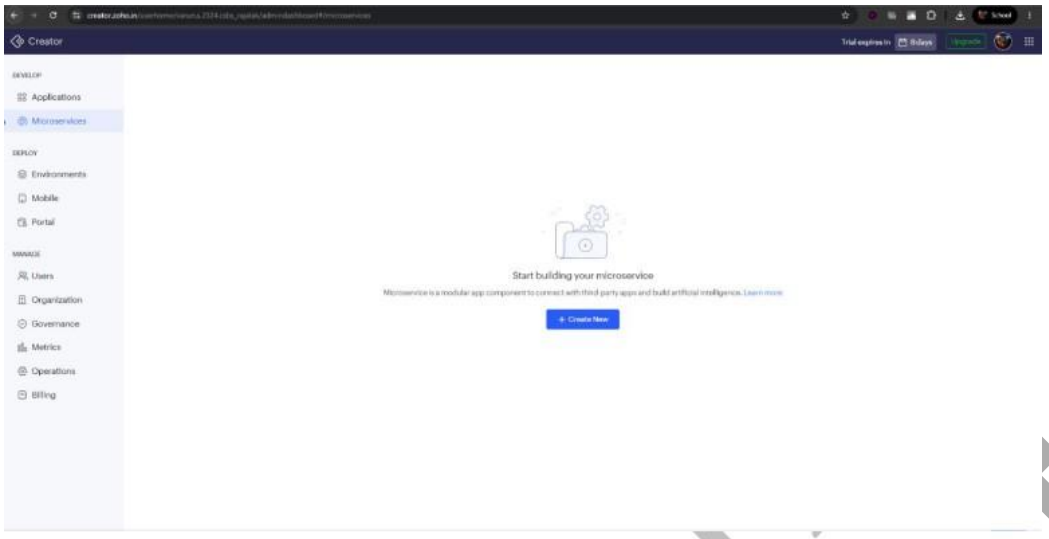


Fig 2: The Microservices page, waiting for the first microservice to be created.

The Microservices module lets developers build small, modular pieces of functionality that can connect with third-party applications or even help build artificial intelligence features into an app. Instead of one giant application doing everything, a microservice handles one specific job on its own.

Since I have not built anything here yet, the screen just shows a friendly "Start building your microservice" message with a "Create New" button. Think of this section as a toolbox for advanced users, where instead of adding more features directly into the main app, you build separate mini-components that plug into it. It is a bit more technical, but the interface still keeps it simple with just one clear button to get started.

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Environments

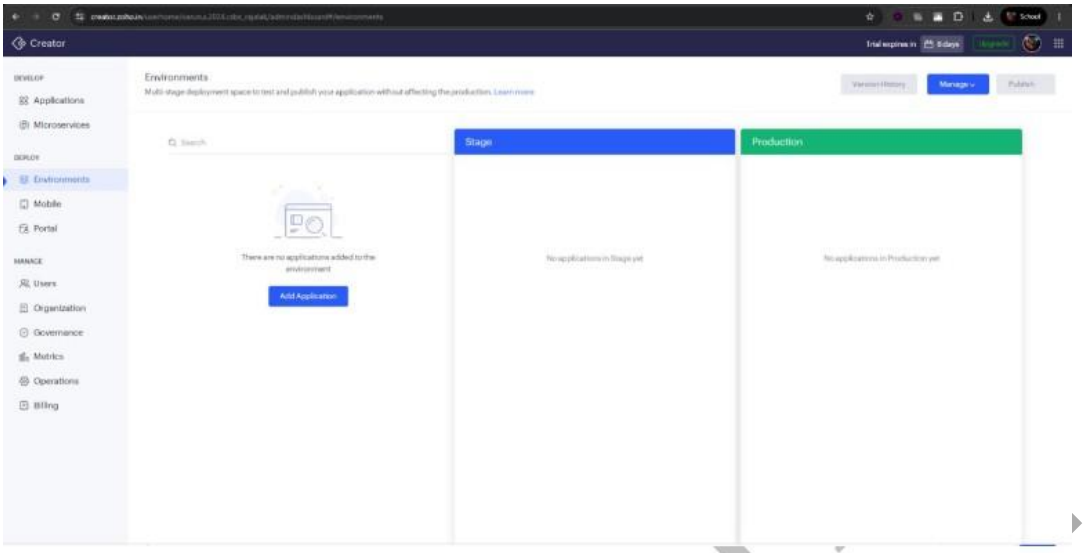


Fig 3: The Environments page, with empty Stage and Production zones.

The Environments module provides a multi-stage deployment space where applications can be tested before they are published live. It is divided into two zones, Stage and Production, so that changes made to an app do not directly affect the version that real users are using.

In plain terms, this is like a safety net. The Stage side is where you can experiment and test an app, almost like a practice ground, and the Production side is the final, live version that customers or employees will actually use. Right now both sides are empty since no app has been added yet, but there is an "Add Application" button ready to go. I really liked this idea because it means you can fix mistakes quietly in Stage before anyone sees them in Production.

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Mobile

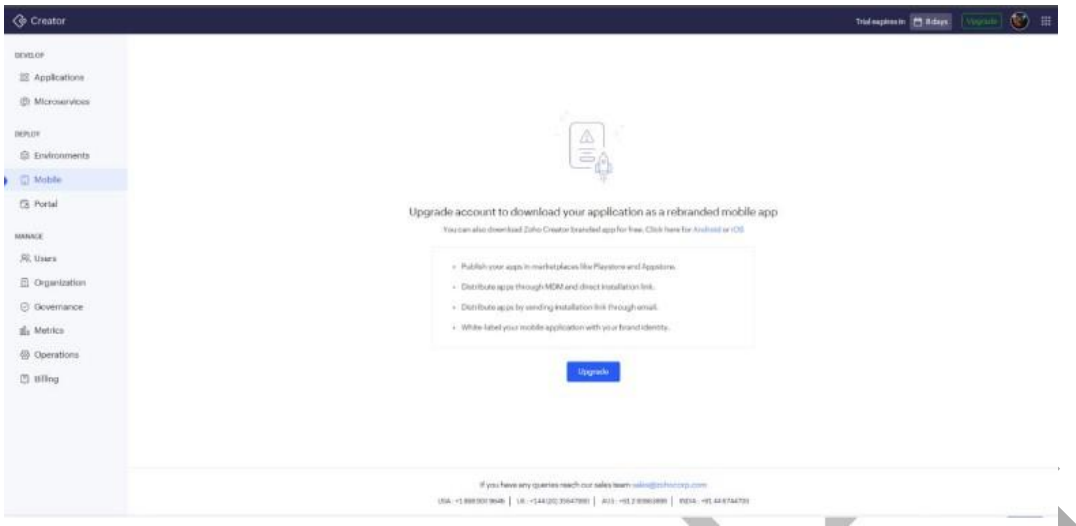


Fig 4: The Mobile page, prompting an account upgrade for rebranded app downloads.

The Mobile module allows applications built on Zoho Creator to be converted into mobile apps and distributed through app stores or direct installation links. On the free trial plan, this rebranding option is locked, and an upgrade is required to unlock white-labelled mobile publishing.

Basically, this page is about turning your web app into something that looks and feels like a proper mobile app with your own logo and branding, rather than the plain Zoho Creator app. Since my account is still on the trial plan, it shows an upgrade prompt along with a short list of benefits, like publishing to the Play Store or App Store, and sending installation links by email. It is a nice reminder that Zoho Creator apps are not limited to desktops, they can travel to phones and tablets too.

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Portal

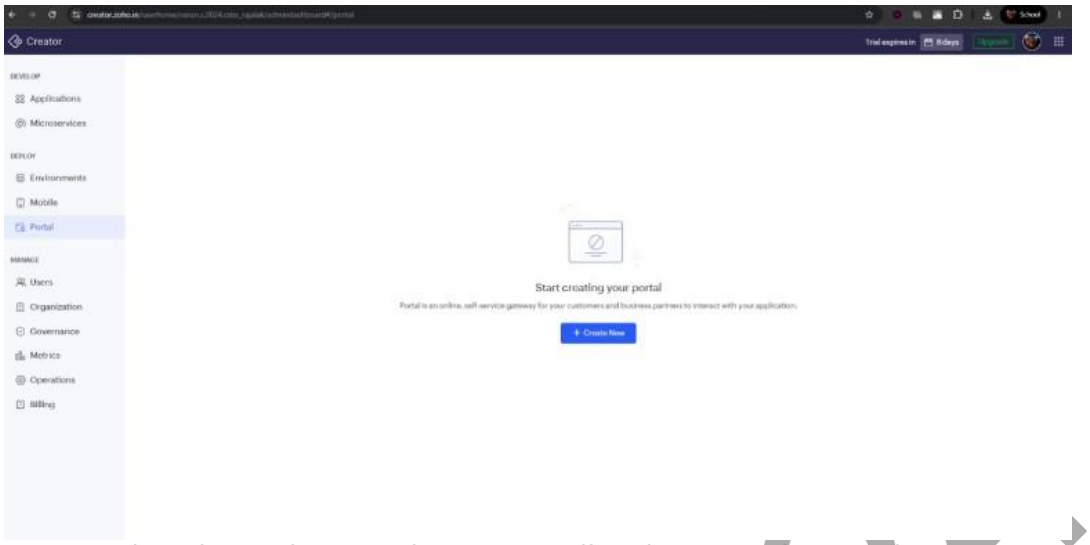


Fig 5: The Portal page, ready to create a self-service gateway for external users.

The Portal module is used to create an online, self-service gateway through which customers and business partners can interact directly with an application, without needing full internal access. It is meant for external users rather than internal employees.

In simpler words, a portal is like a separate front door for people outside the organisation, for example, customers who want to check their order status or submit a request, without seeing the internal admin dashboard at all. The page currently shows a "Start creating your portal" message with a "Create New" button since none has been set up yet. It is a good example of how Zoho Creator thinks about different types of users and gives each of them their own experience.

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Users

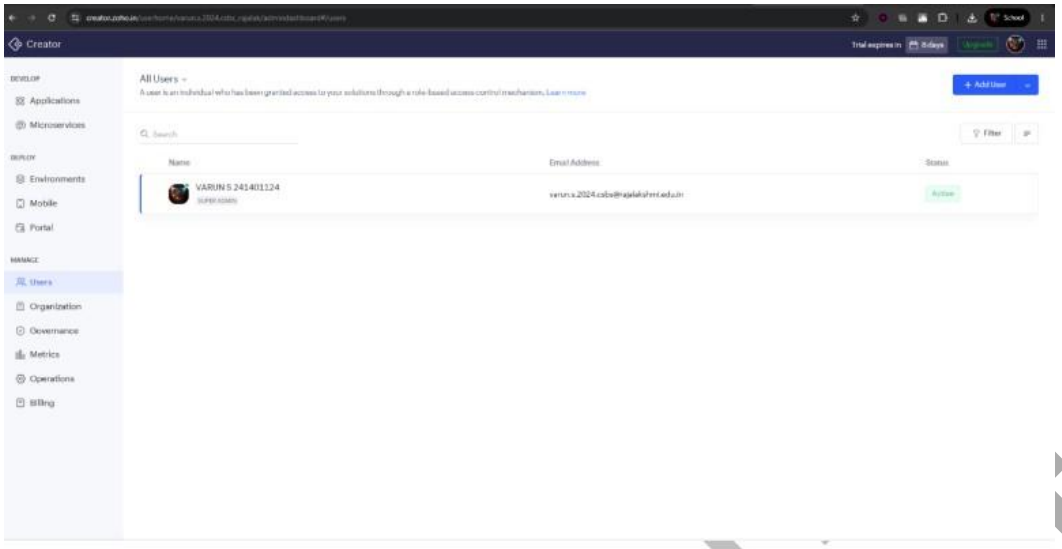


Fig 6: The All Users page, listing account members and their access status.

The Users module displays every individual who has been granted access to the organisation's applications through a role-based access control system. It lists each user's name, email address, and current status, and allows new users to be added through the "Add User" button.

Right now, since I just set up the account, only one user shows up here, me, marked as "Super Admin" and "Active." This module is basically where an admin would manage the whole team, deciding who gets to log in and what role they hold. Role-based access means different users can be given different levels of permission, so not everyone has full control over every application, which is an important safety feature for any real organisation.

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Organization

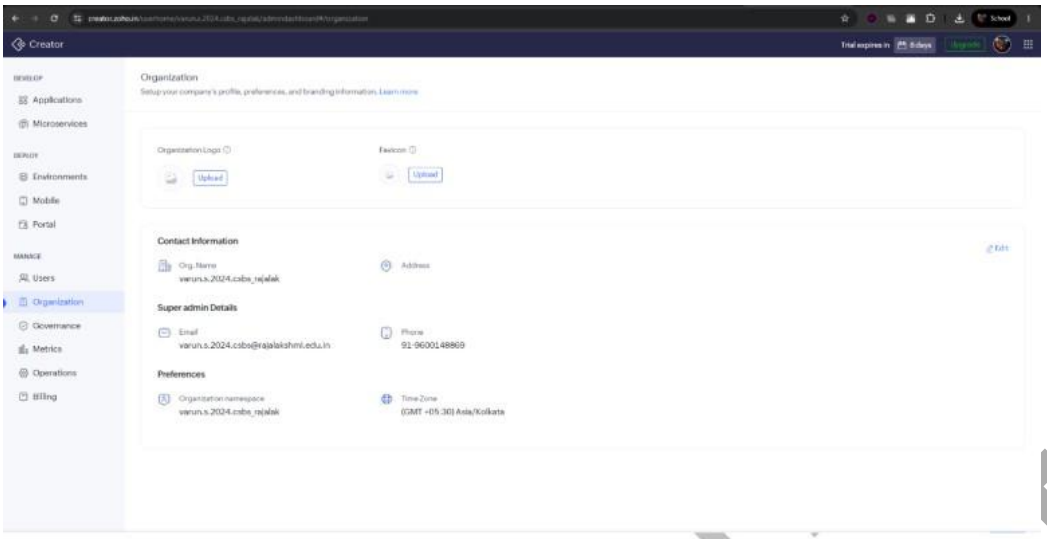


Fig 7: The Organization page, showing company profile, contact, and preference details.

The Organization module is used to set up the company's profile, branding, and general preferences. It includes sections for the organisation logo and favicon, contact information, super admin details, and preferences like namespace and time zone.

This is essentially the "About the company" section of the dashboard. It shows details like the organisation name, the super admin's email and phone number, and the time zone that has been set, which in my case is Asia/Kolkata. There are also upload options for a logo and a favicon, which would help brand every app built under this account. It is a small section, but it plays an important role in giving the whole account a professional identity.

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Governance

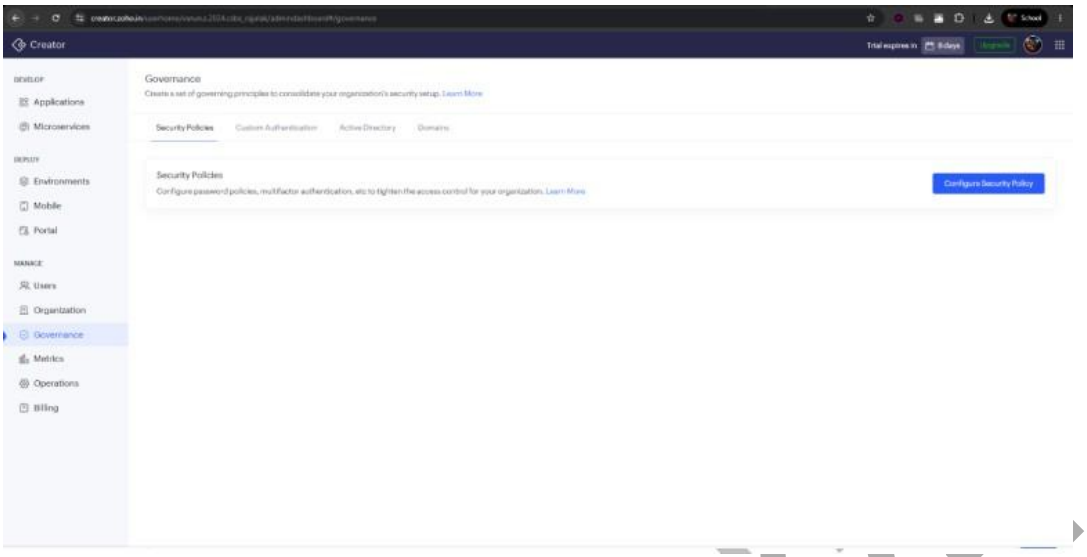


Fig 8: The Governance page, with tabs for Security Policies, Authentication, and Domains.

The Governance module allows administrators to create a set of governing principles that consolidate the organisation's overall security setup. It includes tabs for Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory, and Domains, giving admins control over how users log in and how secure the account is.

In simple words, this is the security control centre of the dashboard. From here, an admin can configure things like password rules and multi-factor authentication to make sure only the right people can access the account. Since low-code platforms are often used to handle real business data, having a dedicated governance section shows that Zoho Creator takes security seriously and does not leave it as an afterthought.

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Metrics



Fig 9: The Metrics page, offering insights once enabled with user consent.

The Metrics module is designed to quickly gather insights, trends, and anomalies for all user activity across applications. Before it can be used, the admin must agree to certain data processing requirements and then click "Enable Metrics."

Basically, this feature works like an activity tracker for the whole account, helping admins understand how their apps are actually being used, who is logging in, and whether anything unusual is happening. It has not been switched on yet in my account, which is why the page shows a simple illustration and a checkbox for consent instead of any charts. It is a good reminder that even monitoring tools need explicit permission before they start collecting data.

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Operations

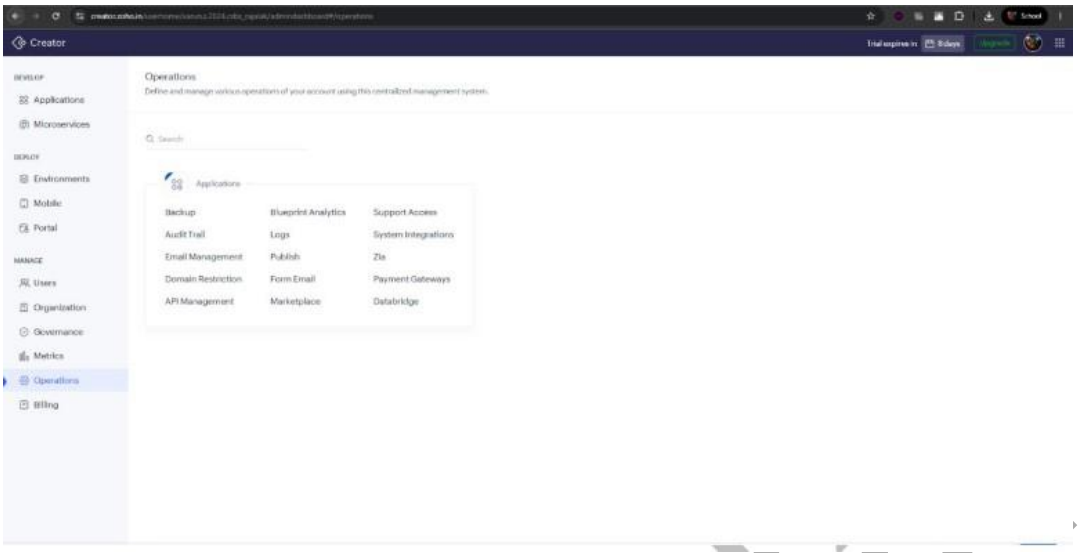


Fig 10: The Operations page, listing centralized management tools for applications.

The Operations module is used to define and manage the various operations of the account through a centralized management system. It groups together tools such as Backup, Audit Trail, Email Management, Domain Restriction, API Management, Blueprint Analytics, Logs, Form Email, Publish, Support Access, System Integrations, Zia, Payment Gateways, Marketplace, and Databridge.

This page feels like the engine room of the whole dashboard. It brings together a long list of behind-the-scenes tools that keep applications running smoothly, from taking backups and checking audit logs to managing APIs and payment gateways. Even the Zia AI assistant is tucked in here. While I have not explored each of these individually, just seeing them listed together gives a good sense of how much is happening under the hood of a seemingly simple drag-and-drop platform.

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Billing

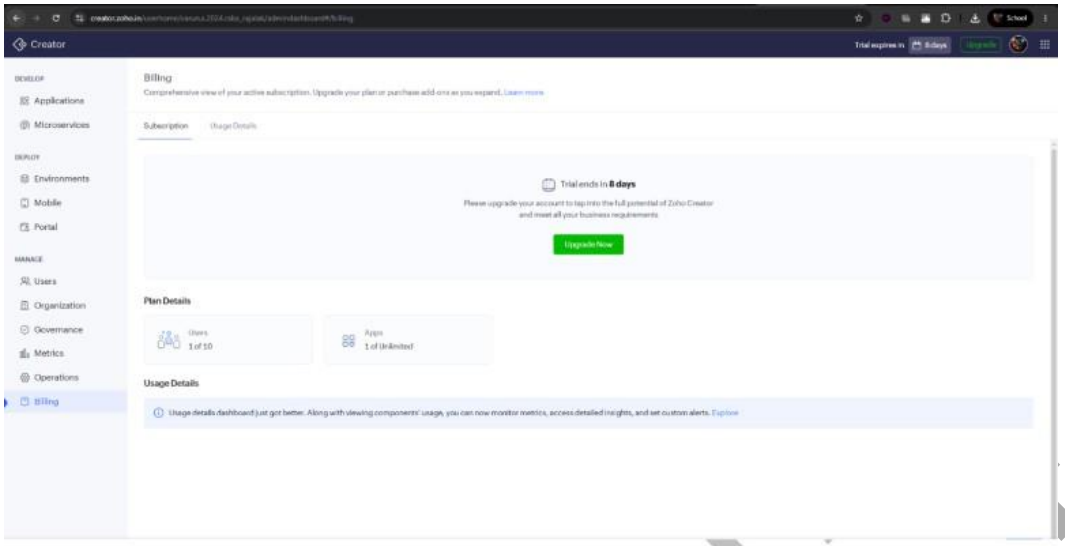


Fig 11: The Billing page, showing the trial subscription and current plan usage.

The Billing module provides a comprehensive view of the account's active subscription. It allows the plan to be upgraded or add-ons to be purchased, and it displays plan details such as the number of users and applications allowed, along with a separate usage details dashboard.

In my case, the page clearly shows that the trial ends in 8 days, along with an "Upgrade Now" button to continue using the platform afterward. The Plan Details section shows that I am currently using 1 out of 10 allowed users and 1 out of unlimited allowed apps. This module makes it easy to keep track of subscription limits without having to dig through separate settings, which is quite convenient for an admin managing costs.

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Zoho Creator Architecture

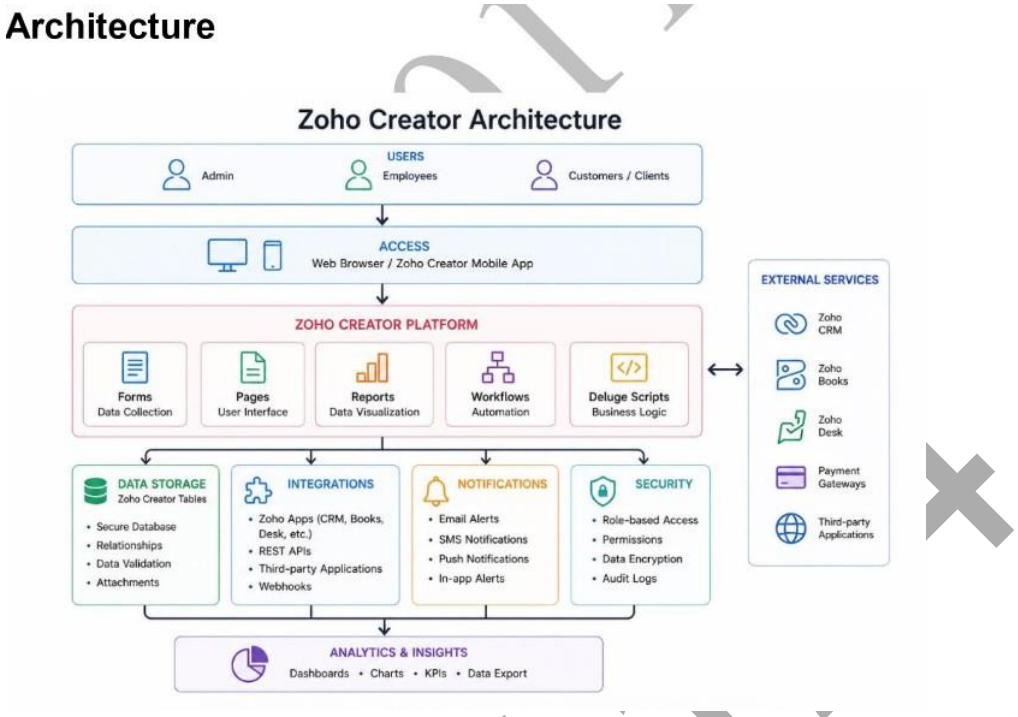


Fig 12: A high-level architecture diagram of the Zoho Creator platform.

This diagram sums up how the whole platform fits together, from the people using it, down to where the data finally lands. At the very top are the users, admins, employees, and customers or clients, who access the platform through a web browser or the Zoho Creator mobile app. Their requests flow into the core Zoho Creator platform, which is built around five main building blocks: Forms for collecting data, Pages for the user interface, Reports for visualizing data, Workflows for automating tasks, and Deluge Scripts for handling custom business logic. Below that layer sits everything that supports the platform behind the scenes, secure data storage in Zoho Creator tables, integrations with other apps and REST APIs, notification systems like email, SMS, and push alerts, and security features such as role-based access, encryption, and audit logs. On the side, the platform also connects outward to external services like Zoho CRM, Zoho Books, Zoho Desk, payment gateways, and other third-party applications. Finally, everything feeds into an analytics and insights layer at the bottom, giving dashboards, charts, KPIs, and data export options. Seeing this diagram really helped me understand that Zoho Creator is not just a form builder, it is a full mini ecosystem with its own storage, security, and connections to the outside world.

Conclusion

Exploring the Zoho Creator Administration Dashboard gave me a much clearer picture of how a low-code platform actually works behind the scenes, and not just the app-building part of it. Each module, from Applications and Microservices to Users, Governance, and Billing, plays a specific role in keeping the platform organised, secure, and easy to manage. What stood out to me the most was how the platform separates concerns so neatly: development tools like Applications and Microservices are grouped together, deployment tools like Environments, Mobile, and Portal form their own section, and everything related to managing the account, Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and Billing, sits under a clear "Manage" category. This kind of

structure makes the dashboard feel much less overwhelming, even for a first-time user like me. The architecture diagram tied everything together nicely, showing how forms, workflows, and scripts on the front end connect to secure storage, integrations, and analytics on the back end. Overall, this exploration helped me appreciate that low-code platforms like Zoho Creator are not just about avoiding code, they are about giving people a well-organised, secure, and scalable environment to build real business applications quickly.

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